The Red Wall

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Near or Far

COL-309701

A Southern Town

???: Phew ...

???: Well, goddamn, civilization at last.

Night has fallen, and a woman in riding boots stops along a sandy road, ahead of her lies a house topped with a wooden cross.

And beyond it, a forest of apricot trees extends all the way to the foothills of the Guadalupe Mountains.

Argus: Hah. "Civilization," turn over every rock in Texas before ever finding that; but a sweet water town like this will do.

Argus: Yeah, it'd do.

To call this a one-horse town would be an insult to horses. But it's somewhere to rest her boots. Argus stashes her jeep nearby and starts walking.

Her experience has taught her that waltzing into such towns in a car is usually unwelcome.

Argus: We ain't far from the border here.

Argus: Shoot, I might have saved time flying to Mexico.

The mercenary takes out a folded piece of paper from her pocket and turns it over.

White and blue, with black pixels forming letters and numbers. The ink is worn away, leaving nothing recognizable of the flight, except the boarding time.

It's a flight ticket.

Argus: Fort Worth to this place ...

Argus: It's been a long drive.

Argus: What was it even for?

Argus: I gotta get this straight when I find—

Argus: ...

Argus: Ugh, never mind.

Argus: Same old pattern. Knock on every door, ask the same old questions, get ready for friction ...

Argus: Let's go.

The melody of 99 Bottles of Beer wafts in from the edge of the town, accompanied by the clinking of glasses.

No matter where you go, you'll never find a better source of leads than a watering hole.

Argus: There you are.

The mercenary hunts with her ears instead of her eyes tonight. She follows the melody down the street and into the bar.

Bar

Argus: Howdy. Get me a mug of ...

She looks around as she considers her order. Those gathered are playing cards and drinking. The tables are piled over with empty cups and plates.

It's long past any respectable meal time. All Argus can order is a drink, rather than chance it on whatever would still count for food at this hour.

Argus: Black Jack.

The bartender eyes the newcomer, confused, as if he hasn't quite understood the words.

Bartender: Pardon?

Resident I: You're in the wrong place, Yankee. What are you trying to impress us with all that?

Resident I: Not that it's a half-bad get up, but a cowgirl you ain't ... How's about you take off those chaps and give 'em here?

Resident I: Not like you'll put 'em to any use.

Argus: Hmm? Jeez. You were talkin' to me?

Argus: Sorry, didn't hear you, little fella. In fact, I almost missed you.

Resident I: What the hell are you trying to ...

Argus: And one more thing, I ain't no Yankee.

Argus: What do I gotta do, whistle "Blue Rose of Texas" for you to prove it? Oh c'mon, give those ears and eyes of yours to those in need if you ain't using them.

Argus: What is it those suits back in Austin say? Umm ...

Argus: Oh, right! "Peace and love."

Argus: Looks like you folks could use some of that.

She smiles, tapping her gun carelessly. A habit she's never truly kicked.

The bartender signals the drunk man to calm down before he reaches for his own pistol, catching him just in time. Then snaps his fingers to grab her attention.

Bartender: Hey, hey! Woah, ma'am, easy. I'm sure he didn't mean no offense.

Bartender: Ain't many new folks that come around here, much less the kind that order a Black Jack. I'd wager most of these lushes never even heard of it.

Argus: So, you got it or not?

Bartender: I do.

The bartender puts down his hand and starts pouring whiskey, his eyes fixed on Argus's gun. His own is just under the bar, but he has his doubts he could outdraw her.

Bartender: It's on the house. Take it as an apology.

A beer jug is put on the counter. The bartender shrugs his shoulders, indicating that there's no whiskey glass on offer.

Bartender: We gonna stay friendly?

Argus: Save it, friend. I've got the money.

Argus: But if you're fixing to apologize, answers will do better than drinks.

The bartender frowns.

Bartender: You a ranger?

Argus: Damn, you ain't lying then. You really don't get many new faces round here, do ya?

Argus: I expected Black Jack drinkers to be a rare sight, but you're really confusing me for a cop?

Bartender: Only cop around here is the county deputy, ma'am.

Argus: Then you must watch too much TV.

Argus glances at the jug and drags it to her side. It'll do.

Bartender: Ain't much to do round here, ma'am. The next episode of Law & Justice is about all we get to look forward to.

Argus: Alright, Mr. Attorney. Have you seen a Texan girl about 5 foot 3, chestnut-colored hair, green eyes?

She takes out a few bills from the pocket, along with the flight ticket.

The bartender moves the money over to the pile.

He fiddles with the stack while answering Argus's question without any sign of interest.

Bartender: Not that I ever seen.

Argus: You sure about that? Think harder.

Argus rubs her finger against the flight ticket. Her tone says it plain. This is not an answer she can accept.

Bartender: This place don't get visitors every day, ma'am. I remember the faces of everyone who comes in here, and there's no way I'd forget a girl like that.

Bartender: But if that girl did come here, and now you're looking for her ... well, it ain't a good sign.

Argus: What do ya mean?

Bartender: Last time now, you really ain't a cop?

Argus: How about you stop asking questions, and start giving answers, pronto.

Her hand hard pounds on the counter as a warning.

Bartender: Yeah, you ain't a cop.

Bartender: But I still don't get you. Coming in here like Johnny Law with that shotgun, what's your angle?

Bartender: Don't you know ...

The bartender stops mid-sentence, taking a moment to look around.

Argus: Huh? Know what? What is it, cat got your tongue?

Argus: If it's money you want, just say so—

Bartender: Ah. You're here on a pilgrimage, ain't you?

Bartender: Damn it all, I should've known. The way you play with that gun, that hungry look in your eyes, and your questions ... Gawh.

Bartender: That dump out there is not worth it.

Bartender: And I'm sure the girl you're lookin' for is not ...

The mercenary runs out of patience. She interrupts the bartender with a swift motion.

As her dagger and a wad of cash smash on the bar top.

Argus: Enough dancing around the subject. I ain't in the mood for it.

Argus: Two choices: say what you're fixing to say, or point me to someone else who will.

The bartender says nothing. He stares down at the flight ticket, now flattened by the dagger.

Bartender: Fort Worth? You drove all the way down here to find this girl?

Bartender: No one passes through this town, least of all Yankees. Unless they've got something they're looking for—and I ain't talking about the view.

Bartender: Hey, Daryl!

The bartender calls out to the familiar face of the customer that had argued with Argus.

Daryl: Yeah?

Argus: I said, I ain't a northerner!

Bartender: The lady here's down from Fort Worth, looking for the wall and a girl with chestnut-colored hair, green eyes—

Argus: Hey! I did mention a girl, but I ain't said nothing about no goddamn wall.

Argus: I have no idea what you're talking about!

Daryl: Jesus!

As Argus looks at the man, he stands up, strangely sobered, and rushes toward the door.

Faster than Argus has no time to react.

Argus: What are you ...

Bartender: **She's a f**king merc!** Grab the deputy!

Bartender: I'll hold her here!

Argus: No, what?!

Argus: **What the hell is going on?!**

Bartender: I'm sorry, ma'am. Like I said, the wall ain't no place of pilgrimage.

Bartender: And I ain't about to stomach any more of your questions.

The bartender pulls his revolver out from under the counter. He manages to bring it to bear on Argus too fast for her to draw.

Not even a greenhorn could miss the shot at this range.

Argus: No ...

Argus: Chill, pal. Where's that Texan hospitality?

Not Visitors

COL-309702

Argus: There's gotta be ...

Argus: Some kinda misunderstanding.

Bartender: Afraid not, ma'am.

She's no longer the one holding all the cards.

Argus: And what happens if that goes off?

Bartender: An uninvited merc from out of town? One brandishing her gun. I think the deputy will understand. If he even gets called, maybe we just take a trip out to that wall of yours and we'll paint it another shade of red.

Bartender: And if need be, I'm sure our friendly local deputy will vouch for us.

Argus: I still have no goddamn idea what you're talking about. What wall?

Argus: You talking like the Alamo or something?

Argus: The bartender motions his revolver up and down. Argus raises her hands and slowly steps back.

Argus: Alright, I see I've hit a nerve. I've got a wallet, you wanna grab it, take anything you want except the photo. Go on.

Argus: Heck, you may want to check the photo if you like. Maybe it'll remind you of something.

Bartender: Don't move!

Argus doesn't even have to turn her head to know that the other patrons have blocked the exits.

Escape seems unlikely without some help.

Argus: *sighs* We really got to do this? Can't we talk?

Argus: There's no need to get rough.

She stammers out again, but she catches the bartender as his eyes drift from her to the door.

Argus: Hm?

There are footsteps outside, every other step coming noticeably slower, as if from a limp.

Bartender: Bar's closed!

Bartender: Oh! It's you!

This is her chance.

Argus: Not sure who it is.

Argus: But I'm guessing your deputy ain't got a hobble.

Her words come along with a swift roundhouse kick.

The revolver is kicked from his hand and falls. Time seems to slow ...

But not for Argus. She grabs the revolver from the air and hops over the counter at blinding speed. In a flash, the muzzle is against the bartender's temple, and her arm locks his neck from behind.

She is back in control before anyone can pull a trigger.

Argus: Let me be clear, folks. I'm still not looking for trouble.

Argus: Hey you, new guy. Best you leave now.

???: ...

The newcomer is tall but thin as an old wood post. Ignoring Argus's warning, he moves straight to the counter, as if unaware of the scene. A bundle of furs draping over his shoulder covers his face.

He places them on the counter, making an audible thud in the deadly quiet bar.

Hunter: Среда.
<Wednesday.>

Hunter: Увидимся в следующем месяце.
<See you next month.>

Argus: Is that Russian?

Argus: Wait, why's his leg bleeding?

The newcomer seems completely out of place in the room. As he takes his money from the counter, Argus realizes that no one has made any sound since he came in.

Hunter: Вам нужна какая-то помощь?
<You need any help?>

Bartender: No.

Argus understands nothing of the man's words. But upon hearing "no," the strange figure nods and limps his way toward the door.

Argus has no intention of lowering her guard. She keeps an eye on the newcomer until he exits the bar.

Argus: Alright, pal. New question.

Argus: Who was that?

Bartender: The deputy will be around any second, lady. Whatever you want, you ain't gonna ...

Bartender: Urgh!

Argus pushes the muzzle hard against his temple again.

Argus: Ain't no deputy here now, is there? So, best think before you speak.

Bartender: He brings in those furs and takes our money. We ... We just do business. That's all.

Bartender: He's a hunter. Brings in fresh meat and furs from time to time. Why, what's it matter?

Argus: Thought you said there was nothing worth hunting around here?

Bartender: No. He drives down from—Oklahoma, or Colorado maybe. Wait, why is that any of your business?

Argus: Do I really got to remind you of your situation? Shame.

Argus: Fine, back to my first question, you wanna answer it now?

Bartender: Get outta here.

Resident II: Cut the crap, Adam.

Resident II: You weren't even around when your sister died. What right do you got to say anything?

Bartender: ...

Argus: Your sister?

Argus squints her eyes.

Bartender: ...

Argus: ...

Silence can be the best means of resistance.

Resident II: Stop it. Let him go.

Resident II: Haven't you damned mercs taken enough from us?

Argus: ...?

Resident II: Hear me now, you'll all end up dead under that wall.

Resident II: The whole lot of you!

Argus: Alright, is anyone in this goddamn town gonna tell me ...

Argus: What the hell is this wall?

???: Enough pretending.

???: Whoever it is that hired you ...

???: We'll figure it out soon enough. So, drop your weapon.

Resident II: Deputy Flynn! Finally.

Argus: You seem like a reasonable man, but ...

Deputy Flynn: Watch yourself. If you fire that gun, I'll have to turn you over to the state police.

Deputy Flynn: You sure you want us poking into your background? I'm going to guess you didn't bring that a gun like that 'round here for hunting.

He drawls out each word as if intentionally playing up his accent, but raises his tone at the end as an open question.

Argus: You got that much right. It's not for hunting.

Deputy Flynn: You an arcanist? They oughta lock you folks up, unless you're doing something useful like working for a company. But you're here on your own, ain't you?

Deputy Flynn: No wonder you kicked up this fuss. Just like your kind to fly off the handle, all feelings, no brains.

Argus: ...

Argus: I only came to look for a girl.

Deputy Flynn: Try again, ma'am. You ain't the first to come 'round with that old excuse. No one's buying it.

Deputy Flynn: So, how about you drop that gun and come quiet-like?

[English text unavailable]

COL-309703

With the interrogation over, the deputy decides not to hold her any longer. Her gun, however, is confiscated pending "good behavior" until she leaves town.

But Argus isn't about to walk out without her gun. Not ever.

Deputy Flynn: You're free to go, ma'am. So, go on, skedaddle.

Deputy Flynn: I advise you not to go too far from town while you're here. It's dangerous out there. Especially now that I've got your piece.

Deputy Flynn: I've gotta go on patrol now. We'll talk later.

Argus: Fine.

Argus nods, concealing an eye roll, as the deputy drives away. Judging from his direction, she'll have a few hours before he's back.

A small window of opportunity, but the work needs to be done.

Argus: Hmph.

Argus: The sun's coming up soon. I'll have to bust myself back into that pig pen before daybreak.

Having made a decision, Argus walks toward the edge of the town.

Argus: That is an old lock, a very goddamn old lock.

Argus: *hiss*

Argus: Gotcha.

Argus: Urgh!

Her one good eye becomes increasingly strained in the harsh darkness. She has to eat a Picrasma candy and wait for it to take effect.

Argus: *deep breath* Let me see.

The next second, the Hundred-Eyed Giant is up again.

Her sight becomes clearer. The mercenary at last reaches the interrogation room.

It took her more time and effort than expected to sneak in without being noticed. Fortunately, she has enough Picrasma candies.

Argus: Where are you, baby?

Argus: There you are, darling! I'm never letting you out of my sight again.

After securing her gun, she looks over a map of the town.

Argus: This county's too small for an archive. Anything they've got on these murders is going to be stored here.

Argus: I guess I'll have to poke around.

Files and cabinets cover every corner of the room, but she doesn't have time to search them all. She needs a lead.

Some fresh dandruff, new wrinkles and creases, marks with less dust ... Every detail tells a story.

Argus: He must have opened these files right after I left.

Argus: ...

Argus: Ah, small town security at its finest. Just like a stupid kid stuffing dirty magazines under his bed. Why bother with a safe?

The dim table lamp forces her to maintain her arcane skill constantly. Her eye becomes tired and sore, but she pushes on to find the real truth behind this Red Wall.

Argus: "Missing persons ... 1962, 1973 ..."

Argus: "Car crashes ... drowning ..."

She's close to the end of the file, with no hints about the Red Wall to be found.

Argus: "Serial murders ..."

Argus: No! Wait!

Argus: Ugh!

Argus: ...

Her eye goes blind again. She's accustomed to the feeling of it fading. Even so, she holds out for a little longer.

Then another candy as she waits for her sight to return.

Her time is running short, with her eye functioning again, she picks up the pace.

Argus: Broken wall ... "1981 ... 1984 ... Wall of the San Diego Hospital ..."

Argus: San Diego Hospital? A field hospital?

Argus: So, that's what the Red Wall is? No murders?

Argus: This is weird.

Argus: But nothing else mentioned a wall, and that deputy only took this file out. There's gotta be something I'm missing.

Argus: The Red Wall's location ... Let me see ...

Argus: What? They didn't write it down!

Argus: But why?

As Argus thinks it over, something else draws her attention.

A pouch tied with red thread, clearly intended to hold files.

There is a scarlet seal on the pouch. She has no clue what it is, or who it came from, but one thing's for sure. It's meant to keep you out.

Argus: Looks like I've hit the jackpot.

Just a Drink of Water

COL-309704

Argus checks the pouch carefully.

Argus: The deputy's name has been signed on the lower right corner for most files.

Argus: Except one, just one—where his signature is on top.

Argus: This has gotta be something.

She pops another two candies down, as her eye regains focus in the dark.

Argus: If I break this seal off, it ain't going back on … F**k it.

Argus: I'll just read it fast.

Argus browses the file at lightning speed. Her eye shines brightly, too brightly perhaps, as a trickle of red pools under her eyelid.

Argus: "1961 … 1963 … 1966 … Missing Hippie, case closed."

Argus: But, not this one.

Argus: "October, 1984 … ritual sacrifices found near the crime scene …"

Argus: "Animal furs scattered around the scene. The blood is confirmed to be non-human …"

Argus: "1985 … Texas rangers officially take charge due to slow progress …"

Argus: …

Argus: And after that … nothing? But there were still missing people around here even up to last year.

Argus: Kayla, why did you come to this place?

Argus: All these cases … and they only solved three of them.

Argus: Almost all of the victims appear to have gone missing after being sighted near the Rio, but none of them seem to have been going to Mexico.

Argus: Kayla …

Argus: No!

Argus stares at the files.

Veins run up her head and fists, like a nest of snakes ready to attack.

Argus: No.

Argus: If they … if these humans can't find her …

Argus: I'll do their job for them.

Argus: I'm the only one who can.

Blood and Violence

COL-309705

Argus: Hah, "Sweet Strawberry."

Argus: Let's hope it's a fitting name.

Their "rodeo" is just a few old cowboys and ranchers standing around a riding pen. Modest in every way, except for the bull.

He is two tons of rippling Texas beef covered in deep gray scars. Snorting hellfire and stamping before they even put the flank straps on.

"Sweet Strawberry": Snort ...

Resident I: Woah, woah! Easy there, big fella! I ain't stupid enough to challenge you.

The bull knocks the sides of the fence with its horns aggressively, causing the crowd to step back.

Wade: Miss, I think you oughta reconsider that bet you made with Adam.

Wade: Thing is, Miss, this ain't a game. I've seen ol' Strawberry flatten out men twice the size of you. It wouldn't do right by me to have to bury a clueless girl.

Argus: So, you think a girl can't hack it, do ya? Well, now I've got one more reason to prove you boys wrong.

Argus: Don't worry now. I ain't going to ask for a red cent after all this. I got my own reward lined up.

Wade: *sighs* Here are the reins.

Wade: On the count of three, you need to link it to the buckle on his back. Remember now, don't get on until you make sure it's buckled tight.

Wade: You gotta get steady as quick as you get up there. Grab the rope, hold on, don't think of nothing else. Not the horns, not the ground. As soon as your ass hits his back, the stopwatch starts counting.

Resident I: Enough with the lecture, Wade. The little lady's clearly an expert. Hand her the rope, and we'll see what God's got in store for her.

Resident II: Get along now! You know how much these lights cost to run?

A harsh beam of light shines on Argus's face, like deer caught out on a highway. The whole thing feels unnecessary, given it's broad daylight.

Still, she hops over the fence and grasps the rope from below the bull's belly. It's coarse and heavy, liable to wear a hole in her gloves if she makes it to the end.

Wade: You ready?

Argus: Any time now.

Wade: Good. One, two, three ...

Wade: Hit it!

He swings a copper pipe down across an iron board to signal the start, and Argus straddles the bull steadily.

"Sweet Strawberry": Snort ... Snort!

In an instant, "Sweet Strawberry" charges out toward the middle of the field, as he does his back buckles up and down with astounding force, and he begins to spin like a top.

Argus clings hard to the rope and entwines it around one of her hands. Each time the bull bucks, she twists another circle round until her hand is fully tied in.

Argus: Hey, hey!

Argus: Woah, buddy! *coughs*

Wade: Three ...

The three seconds in; as he rocks her up, she accidentally bites down on her tongue, realizing too late there is a reason you never hear bull riders yell.

Just as she had expected, the rope has already cut through her gloves, it slices open the skin of her hand from her index finger to her thumb.

"Sweet Strawberry": Snort! Snort!

Wade?: Five ...

The fifth second passes. She's lost all sense of sight and sensation besides pain. Her teeth are clenched. There's no conscious thought in her head—only the instinct to hold on.

The rope at least feels less coarse after being drenched in blood and sweat, but now it's slippery instead.

She tries to hold on to it with all her might.

Argus: Ugh!

Wade?: Seven ...

The seventh second, it feels as if that pipe were hitting her brain instead of the board. Her muscles are exhausted and cramped. She begins shaking involuntarily. She can't hold on ...

Wade?: Hang in there!

Argus: Ugh!

The pipe hits the board for the ninth time. Argus can't help herself, as he bucks again, her grip fails and she flies off of the behemoth in a violent twist. Fortunately, it's her shoulder that hits the ground first, not her head.

The world becomes dark and silent for a second. Even so, she can feel the eyes of everyone around her.

"Sweet Strawberry": Snoooort!

Her sharp senses save her life once more. As the bull turns around to stomp on her, she opens her eyes and manages to roll up to her feet, evading his charge.

Her arm is twisted—maybe broken, but she won't give up—not until she finds Kayla.

Argus runs for her life, jumping the fence in a fluid motion before stumbling toward Wade.

Wade: Sweet Jesus!

Resident I: No f**king way! She did it?!

Resident I: Even the Texas state champ only managed eight seconds on him.

Argus: What's my time? What is it?!

Argus: Tell me!

She yells in a hoarse voice; her mouth is bruised and bloodied.

Argus: Ten seconds, right?! I made it! You all saw it!

Wade: Urgh!

Argus: You! Don't you dare fool me.

Wade: No, no. That was unbelievable, little lady. It's just ... it was nine.

Wade: I didn't get to the tenth strike.

Argus: What ...

Argus: You can't be serious.

Wade: I'm sorry, Miss. Seems you lost your bet.

Wade: But, I gotta say that was a ride for the legends. I've never seen anyone handle Strawberry like you did. We'll tell Adam what we saw.

Argus: ...

Argus: Hah.

As night falls again, silence returns to the town. Two people are walking toward the shallows of the river.

Argus hurts all over, not helped in the slightest by the post she punched after finding out her time.

Bartender: After you reach the shallows, go straight ahead 200 yards. Then, you'll see that half iron gate. The Red Wall's right behind it.

Bartender: You're on your own from here.

Argus: Thanks.

Bartender: Nine seconds. I gotta hand it to you, ma'am. That took grit. That kind of grit you don't see much anymore ... if only I had that—

Bartender: Forget it. It ain't gonna change nothing for me.

Argus: But it was only nine seconds. I lost the bet. So, why hold up your side of the bargain?

Bartender: Think of it as a consolation prize. 'Cause I still ain't telling you nothing about my sister.

Bartender: Besides, you gave me the prize money. So, it's only fair. Good luck, ma'am.

Argus: Thanks. I think I'll need it.

Bartender: Oh, and another thing. You know, just because you showed you got grit doesn't mean you get free reign here. Wade's right upset about the damage you did to his fence.

Argus: Fine. I've been out here for a long time. I know the boundaries.

They bid a respectful goodbye before Argus continues her journey alone. The night grows dark fast, leaving her all but blind. So, she simply follows her instinct.

Fireflies offer brief bursts of light by Argus's wrist before swirling back into the brush. Argus stands in front of the iron gate, her vision still faint even with the help of the torch bugs.

Her heart flutters as she passes through.

Argus: The deep iron smell of blood is stronger ahead. She must be going the right way.

Argus: Keep your eyes peeled, Argus.

She takes out a Picrasma candy and swallows it like a pill.

There is no time for chewing.

Argus: Even with the moon out I still can't hardly see ... that could be a wall though.

Argus: But what's that all over it?

Argus: *deep breath* Come on.

Argus: And thence we came forth to see again the stars.

Argus: Argus casts her arcane skill while moving forward.

Radiance flashes in Argus's eyes, showing her the true color of the Red Wall.

Argus: ...!

Argus: What?

Argus: Blood?

Argus: Why is there so much blood here?

Never Enough

COL-309706

The Red Wall

Argus: Urgh!

Argus: Sure, the file said there'd be blood and fur, but ...

Argus: This is something else altogether ...

Argus: Am I seeing things?

The reality is more horrendous than any she could imagine. She closes her eyes and opens them again, yet the scene remains unchanged.

The blood is already dry, yet the odor is strong enough that it stings the air as she approaches.

Argus: *retches* Damn it, that's real blood.

Argus: Everywhere ...

Argus: These old stains ... they're oxidized human blood, but this fresh stuff ... it's not from a human.

Argus: Ugh, a skinned hare.

She tries her best to recognize the bodies from their shape.

Argus: Ugh! *vomits*

Argus: Who skinned these animals? They've done nothing to preserve them. Smells like hell warmed over—

Argus: Urgh!

Argus: But ...

Argus: This is a lot of fur. Could be more than what that hunter brought yesterday.

Argus: All I know it was a huge bundle. Looked like they were from large game too.

Argus swallows another candy so she can examine the fur more carefully and compare them to her memory.

Argus: Hares, deer hide, bearskins, racoon, dogs ... or wolves.

Argus: And fish too, though only the scales are left. Could be to reflect some light?

Argus: A veritable buffet of wildlife, but who told them skinwalkers like fur?

Argus: They've got their own.

Argus: But there ain't no blood or hair from Kayla. Good.

Argus: Couldn't ask for better news than that, really.

Argus: ...

Argus: Wait, this stain is fresher than the others.

Argus: Is that sheep's blood?

She doesn't approach the blood stain.

She already knows how sticky it is. She has felt it before.

A tanned-skin woman opens her arms, showing her sticky palms.

Blood and amniotic fluid stick to her skin and refuse to drop.

Argus: I don't think it's gonna work, Kayla.

Kayla: Why? You were doing so well.

Kayla: This'll be the last lamb. You gonna do it or leave it to me?

The girl smiles, with anticipation in her eyes.

Argus: Look at my hands.

Argus: I think that's gonna be a no.

She shrugs her shoulders, shaking some of the blood off her hand.

Argus: But I still don't get it.

Kayla: You said that's life, I understand that.

Kayla: But if we don't help it get out and stand like its siblings ...

Kayla: It ain't gonna make it. Its mama will stay here to protect it, and then they'll both get gobbled up by the skinwalker.

Kayla: Weakened ewes are their favorites. They make for the best disguises.

Argus: A "skinwalker"?

Kayla: What? You don't know?!

Kayla: Say it ain't so ...

Despite her words, she's laughing.

Kayla: You really ain't never heard it? Well, then it's up to me to tell you.

Kayla: So, a skinwalker is ... hmm ...

Kayla: Let me put it this way. You ever got the feeling that someone you know was all the sudden replaced? Like they look the same, but they ain't, you know?

Argus: No.

Argus: My eyes see through things, you know. People, too.

She stands up, wiping her hands down on her worn, patchy jeans.

Kayla: *chuckles*

Kayla: But still, they might not be sharp enough to see through the camouflage of a skinwalker.

Kayla: They look the same as humans, but they can take the skin from living animals and use them like camouflage. That way they can get real close so they can eat them alive or turn them into their kind.

Kayla: They are the most feared hunter in the wilderness.

Argus: It's just a story. Even if it's real, ain't no monster can hide from my eyes.

Argus: And I've got your back.

Kayla: That's true. The one-hundred-eyed giant's got my back.

Kayla: Now let's help this little lamb, shall we?

Argus: That's right.

Argus: Ain't no monster can hide from my eyes.

The Picrasma candy begins to wear off again, and her sight fades.

She recalls the words again, as if she were savoring the candy's aftertaste.

Argus: "People will leave fur and flesh near the scene of the crime on the hottest days, hoping the skinwalkers will take their offerings and leave them be. But it don't help none."

Argus: "These monsters don't never stop hunting. It's in their nature. That bloody-red ox will be standing on its rear legs as it shows up that night, holding those furs dangling from its mouth like a banner."

Argus: "And it'll be a bloodbath all the same. Humans' and animals' bodies piled together."

Argus: "All living things treated equally, no exception."

Argus: A massacre that lasted a long time ... "Humans' and animals' bodies piled together," just like this.

Argus: But it didn't work. People are still disappearing.

Argus: ...

Argus: I'll track it down myself.

Argus: Whether the bastard's a merc or a skinwalker, I'll find it.

Argus: Believe me, I will.

No One Cares

COL-309707

Soon after the sun rises, Argus prepares to leave town.

The fresh sheep blood was not part of the offerings. It was left by the hands of the one who touched the old stains.

Argus: The blood of the sheep matched the old stains from the humans down to the same marks and splatter. It had to be the same weapon. A machete—maybe even a chainsaw.

Argus: This bastard used the same blade for killing sheep and dismembering its victims.

But the murderer—at least one of them—made a mistake. A trail still visible to the mercenary. Maybe even a bit too obvious.

Argus: Goddammit!

Argus: This bastard must have returned there over and over to leave these trails. Like a calling card painted in blood.

Argus: Not a deputy, not a sheriff, not even the Rangers could find them though. Only I can.

Argus: Only I can.

After recalling what she read in the files to exclude some of the suspects, Argus finds her jeep and hits the road again.

She refuels her car whenever there's a gas station, and buys fresh water and bullets whenever there's a store, just as she always does.

Following the trail with her eyes, she drives into the distance.

Roadside Diner

Argus: Hey, could you tell me ...

Diner Owner: I don't know.

Argus: I didn't even ask.

Diner Owner: I just don't know. I don't care who you are, if you ain't ordering anything then move along. I got a full house of customers to serve.

Diner Owner: I do food. Not chitchat. If you're not hungry, you're in the wrong place.

Argus: ...

Argus: Give me a double cheeseburger, onion rings, and a milk shake, whatever flavor will do.

Argus: Can I ask questions now? Or do I gotta play a game of darts with y'all first?

Diner Owner: Yeah, what is it?

Argus: It's about that place with the real tall smokestack to the south, the one fenced in with barbed wire.

Diner Owner: What? You mean the old nuclear power plant. Yeah, it's been abandoned. I'm just glad it's downstream of us.

Diner Owner: But what do I know? Maybe you want a mug of nuclear waste with your burger.

Argus: I ain't kidding. But you said it's abandoned, right? So, no one lives there?

Diner Owner: You got rocks in your ears, sweetheart? I said it was a nuclear power plant, not a condo. Nah, no one lives there. They've got soldiers from the base nearby that patrol around, but I don't see them much these days.

Argus: ...

A wild-goose chase is frustrating. Coming up empty on every site feels like losing all the chips she has won so far in just one hand.

Argus: Could this bastard be moving?

Argus: I still haven't pinned them, but the trails don't lie.

Argus's search is not without some fruits; if nothing else, she can tell its paths are random. The trails lead all over the state.

She has to take the idea of it being a skinwalker into serious consideration.

Argus: Moving randomly, but always on the outskirts of farms, small towns, and remote places ...

Argus: Tsk, so what, I gotta bring salt and holy water with me now?

She's chased him through countless towns and farms, but no luck. Yet somehow, the trails always appear just when Argus thinks she's lost track of them.

Argus: Damn it!

Argus smashes the wheel violently, yet the jeep's horn lets out only a pitiful whistle. At the same time, her fist feels a dull pain, which makes her wonder what she is doing.

Is this a fool's errand? The murderer could be anyone, but still the Hundred-Eyed Giant can't find them.

Argus: No.

Argus: No, it's not.

Of course she will not admit it.

Argus puts the question behind her and leaves for the next site.

Argus: Damn it!

Argus: It's busted.

The jeep fails to turn on the tenth try. Sudden visions of her strangling the smarmy worm of used car dealer that sold her this lemon appear in her head.

Argus: And in the middle of nowhere? Really?

Argus: Let me see. The nearest town is almost 200 miles away from here.

She has searched almost every town, from the Gulf to the Rockies and then some, Argus has to accept the fact that she might have failed.

Argus: Is that it? I've already searched the whole of Texas?!

Argus: Then, is this bastard dead already, or is he still on the run? I guess that would explain all these goddamn clues.

Argus: But ain't no way a skinwalker runs away from a merc out of fear!

Argus: The clues were so obvious at the beginning, as if someone planted them. And I chased them like a good little bloodhound.

Argus: But as soon as I left the south, they got unstable, maybe chaotic. The closer I go to the state line, the worse it's got.

But the trails never disappeared completely. They twinkled like stars in her eyes always provoking her. Always just out of reach.

Eventually, all those clues guide her north towards Colorado. She was just about to cross the Oklahoma panhandle, but that was before her car broke down.

Now fate makes fun of the dogged mercenary by shrouding her in the morning mist.

Argus: But I can't be wrong.

Argus: ...

She can hear her confidence fading away in her voice.

Argus: I can't ...

Argus: Yes, just keep going, Argus, just keep going.

Argus: ...

Argus: Kayla was there. She was in that town with the Red Wall. I must have missed something.

Argus: I need to catch this bastard if I have any chance of finding her.

Argus: Just ...

Argus: Just keep going.

Argus: So what if the car's broken? I've still got two feet.

Argus ditches the lemon right where it broke down, packs her stuff, and starts walking into the vast prairie.

All she carries with her is determination and some basic survival equipment. It's been many long hours since she started walking.

Argus: *sighs* Nothing but sage bush and tumbleweeds. Not a farm, not even a town in sight.

Argus: To sum up, I'm in no man's land.

Argus: Least I can say there's no skinwalkers, if only because there's no skin around to walk in.

Argus: Unless they were borrowing the skin of an old hermit.

She notes the time by the angle of the sun, and her location by the nearby plant life. Wherever else she's headed, she's still on the trail of her target.

But still, she has no idea who it could be.

Argus: ...

Argus: A place as desolate as this only appeals to anti-social psychos and outlaws.

Argus: Phew!

Argus: It's gonna get cold tonight. Better speed up.

She grips her gun even tighter, forgetting to stop and breathe. She waits a while and then presses forward again.

To stay alert and rational after traveling a great distance is not easy for anyone, much less for someone with night blindness.

It's all too easy to miss hidden dangers lurking underfoot.

Argus: ...!

Argus: *hisses*

Argus clenches her teeth, trying to hold in a pained scream. Just because this trap didn't catch an animal, doesn't mean it's safe. Far from it.

Argus: Goddammit!

She tries her best to keep in her pain while moving to the nearest trunk. She sits down slowly and straightens out her wounded leg. It was a simple spring trap, but painfully effective.

Argus leans forward and down to her trapped leg. But she can only fumble in the dark, moving her hand inch by inch, hoping to find the release.

Argus: Oh please, goddammit. I don't wanna waste candy on fixing this mess.

Argus: Ugh!

A few more moments of pain pass before she gives in. If she can't see, she's liable to do more harm than good.

Argus: ...

Argus takes out a candy and swallows it. Then leans forward again to examine the mechanism.

Its structure is crystal clear now.

Argus: There you are.

She hooks a finger round the spring and pulls it out.

Argus: Damn it!

Argus: *deep breath*

She takes a deep breath and attempts to stand.

Argus: Ain't no time to take a break. *pant* Gotta go as far as I can before the effects completely wear off. At least through to the other side of this forest.

Argus: Someone must have put the trap here, and if so, they may be nearby.

Argus: Sorry, it didn't catch you any dinner. Only one dumbass merc.

Argus: Goddammit!

She staggers as she walks forward, but pushes against the pain. Until she reaches the point that she can't help but cry out with each step.

Argus: *sighs* What the hell ...

Argus: ... am I doing?

As she questions herself, the candy's effects taper off. Argus keeps her eyes wide open, but in the darkness sees only vague and blurry shapes.

She stumbles forward for a time, until the sound of footsteps breaks her stride.

Argus: Wait. What ...?

Footsteps that are followed by the loud crack of a rifle. One of the bullets swooshes by her ear.

Something huge behind Argus falls to the ground in a heap. She looks back instinctively.

Argus: A bear ...

The familiar smell of animal fur and blood rushes up into her nose. It reminds her of the Red Wall, but she has no time to think about that. She swivels to the source of the bullets and raises her gun to return fire.

???: Да, медведь.
<Yes, a bear.>

???: Что вы здесь делаете, дамочка?
<What are you doing here, lady?>

Argus: Who ...

Argus sees a blur of orange and yellow. The man speaking to her seems to be carrying a lamp.

Argus: Who are you?!

???: Ты наступил на мою ловушку.
<You stepped in my trap.>

???: Тебе нужно сделать прививку от столбняка.
<A tetanus shot.>

???: И это ...
<Besides ...>

???: Это твое?
<Is this yours?>

Argus: I don't know what the hell you're saying, comrade! But back off!

???: Hmm.

Argus can feel that the source of heat takes a few steps back. Hands trembling, she tries hard to keep her gun raised, and takes out two candies.

She chews them hard, almost gnashing, hoping it will make them take effect faster.

Argus: You ...

The medicine takes quick effect, and gradually her view clears, giving her the image of a familiar tall, thin man.

Argus: It's you?!

Now she understood the target's odd patterns, it wasn't strategy. He was following the hunting seasons, following his prey.

Hunter: So, that's how he does it.

Argus: You ...

Hunter: что вы пытаетесь здесь добиться?
<What are you trying to achieve out here?>

Argus is shocked. All the dots connect at once.

Argus: It was ... it was never a skinwalker at all. You're just some guy from ... somewhere.

Argus: Where even did you come from, Moscow or something?

Hunter: Вы из иммиграционной службы?
<Are you from the immigration office?>

Argus: Goddammit, I don't speak Ruskie. Do you know any English?

Argus: Look, if you can, raise your hands and say something I'll actually understand.

To make him understand, Argus slightly lifts her gun.

Hunter: ...

Hunter: Is this yours?

The man hands over a piece of paper.

Argus: What ...?

Argus had dropped her flight ticket without ever noticing it. The hunter picks it up and returns it to her.

A simple act of kindness, which nonetheless, lights a fuse.

Argus: ...

Argus: Put it down.

Argus: I said, put it down!

Argus steps forward aggressively. Her gun poking the man's chest.

Hunter: Hm?

Hunter: Why?

Argus: You murderer!

Her hands tremble violently. She can barely hold the gun straight.

Hunter: Huh?

Hunter: This is yours.

Argus: ...

He's right about that.

Argus snatches the flight ticket from his hand and puts it away. Her breathing is labored, and the wound on her leg is burning with pain.

Her ears are tingling from the headache. She has to stop thinking and focus on her goal.

Hunter: You ... look for me?

Argus: FBI.

The mercenary flashes a fake badge to frighten him. But the hunter just seems more confused.

Argus: You're under arrest. I'll serve you the warrant once we get back to the station, any station.

The badge has come in handy before, great for scaring random civvies into compliance, but this man, serial killer, skin changer, whatever, he seems immune.

She's taking a risk, but her goal is not to kill the target after all.

Hunter: ...

Hunter: Why?

Argus: I'm investigating a murder case, a serial killer.

Argus: And unfortunately, you're the prime suspect.

Argus: I'm taking you back to San Laredo, the town on the Mexican border, remember?

Argus: You've got a lot of explaining to do to the deputy about ...

Argus: The Red Wall.

[English text unavailable]

COL-309708

Resident I: Adam! Beers!

Bartender: Hold your horses!

Adam leaves the counter, putting an end to the conversation.

Argus: ……♪

Argus had arrived in San Laredo at midnight. After leaving the hunter to the deputy's office, she dressed her wounds again and then returned to the bar.

As the investigation reopens, the news that she caught the murderer spreads through the town like a prairie fire.

Now she's sitting at the bar, finally sipping on the Black Jack she paid for days ago. She isn't in a rush to ask about Kayla just yet, for now, she's enjoying the moment.

Same way she did when she saved that girl the first time, though she was just a baby then.

Wade: Hey, hey! Adam, Daryl!

Wade: Did ya hear? The Ruskie got away!

Argus: What the …! You can't be serious.

Bartender: …

Resident I: Ruskie? Oh, you mean the hunter? Who let him go? It can't have been the deputy, right?

Resident I: If he let him go, he must have had a reason.

Wade: Yeah, the deputy! And unlike how they dealt with the mercs, seems like he didn't even bring in the rangers!

Wade: Time …

Wade stutters when he notices Argus.

Wade: Ugh!

Argus grabs her gun and stands up. She doesn't seem to pay attention to Wade's words.

Argus: Excuse me.

Wade: Where you going, Miss? The deputy let him go. What can you do?

Wade: Look, I saw you in action. You're the best bull rider and merc I've ever known. I don't doubt you must've cracked a whole heck of cases.

Wade: But you got the wrong guy this time.

Wade: That's … That's what the deputy said, anyways.

Argus: …

Bartender: Enough, Wade.

Bartender: Enough.

The hunter didn't leave the town after being released. He went somewhere Argus visited not long ago.

Argus follows his trail to the shallows before the forest. She already knows where the destination is. A broken iron gate …

And behind that, the Red Wall.

Argus: …

Argus: Damn it! Damn it! Damn it!

Despite the wound in her leg shooting stabs of pain across her body, Argus runs across the shallows and enters the woods.

She rushes toward the Red Wall without stop.

The forest looks a bit different from what she remembered. Given that she only saw blurs that night, it's no surprise.

But Argus isn't focusing on her surroundings—just the trail.

Argus: He went that way? Then, he ain't heading for the Red Wall?

Argus: Wait ...

Argus: There's another wall.

Argus: It's the Red ...

Argus: No. It looks almost the same, but this ain't the Red Wall.

Argus: That wall looked much worse.

Argus: ...

Argus: Goddammit! Where'd he go?

Hunter: Ты ищешь меня.
<You are looking for me.>

Argus: ...!

Argus: Damn it!

The mercenary loads her gun and points it at the man, who appears as if from nowhere.

Hunter: You're looking for me.

Argus: Back off. Nice and easy.

The hunter does as she says.

Argus: Further.

Hunter: If I go, then you cannot hear me.

Argus: I ain't fixing to listen. I'm here to take you down.

Argus: But before that, I just need to know ...

Hunter: This is the Red Wall.

Argus: What?

Hunter: You understand English, yes? This is the Red Wall.

Hunter: Did I say wrong?

Argus: No, it can't be.

Argus: I've seen the Red Wall. It's covered in your victims' blood and the marks you left to boast about your slaughter. You even tricked their families into buying your furs.

Argus: Why? Why do you do it?

Hunter: This is the Red Wall. It has no ... no thing you said.

Hunter: Look.

Argus: No!

She doesn't intend to follow his instruction, but she can't help herself.

The wall is dyed red with apricots. The juice, which had to have been poured less than 24 hours ago, flows down like blood, as if it were inexhaustible.

No blood stains, no fur, only red juice and rotten pulp.

The apricots are piled at the bottom of the wall, all smashed up, laughing up at the Hundred-Eyed Giant.

Argus: No.

Argus: This ain't ...

Argus: This ain't the Red Wall.

Argus: You covered it up, cleaned up the crime scene, and someone helped you.

Argus almost drops her gun. She steps forward and grabs the hunter's collar, dragging him close to the wall.

She wishes somehow to see the blood stains and dead flesh that had been there before.

Argus: Someone helped you, didn't they?! Just look at the wall; the proof's all there! I can almost see exactly how you ripped those people apart!

Argus: Someone must've helped you. No doubt about it.

Argus: Otherwise, you couldn't have done this so fast. Not without leaving evidence behind.

The hunter says nothing to defend himself.

He just tilts his head and reaches out for an apricot that looks relatively intact.

Argus: You ...

Argus: What are you doing?

Hunter: This is абрикос <*apricot*>.

He shows the apricot to Argus. It has rotted away on the inside and turned black.

Hunter: This is cattlehide.

He points at the rope hung at his waist.

Hunter: This is the Red Wall.

Then he points at the broken wall covered in apricot juice.

Argus: No, no ...

Argus: It can't be ...

Hunter: That is all.

Hunter: Simple truth.

Argus: What kind of simple truth is that? I don't get it. What in the goddamn are you even talking about?

Argus: If ...

Argus: If all those marks were just apricot pulp ... But there's no way. Apricots ain't red.

Argus: And I smelled the blood.

The hunter shakes his head. He looks at the Red Wall and bites the apricot in his hand.

Hunter: I do not know.

Hunter: Where I come from, абрикосы <*apricot*> can be red sometimes.

Hunter: Red signifies "beauty." It's a good color.

Hunter: And this ...

Hunter: У вас тоже есть красная стена, не так ли?
<You have a red wall too, don't you?>

Argus: I ...

Hunter: You have a Red Wall too.

Argus: ...

Argus: I have ...

Urgh, i-it hurts.

Argus, Argus. You've come to me.

Argus: What do I have ...?

Argus: The Red Wall. Did I fail to see through it?

Argus: Was it the Red Wall that I didn't see through, or ...

Argus: Kayla ain't here.

Argus: Phew! Never mind.

Argus: Look on the bright side. At least I found this ticket.

Argus looks at the sky. She still remembers what she had gone through in the motel.

She still remembers the sticky feeling that oozed from the mirror. To prevent herself from rubbing hands pointlessly, Argus checks the ticket again.

Argus: From Fort Worth to Houston ...

Argus: The passenger name is right. This is the best clue so far.

Argus: If the information is all correct, Kayla must've come through Houston.

Argus: But that can't be her final destination, I guess. She never liked big cities.

Argus: Hmm.

Argus: The buses travel between cities and the countryside twice a day.

Argus: Damn it, Kayla. Where on earth are you?